

England's golden summer evenings.

Enough for cricket's ruling bosses at the ICC to be pleased, though the noisy background score of back-slapping may just be drowning out the distant rumble of thunder.

What was on show and in demand in England this June was not cricket. It was Twenty20 cricket, the fastest, most spectator-friendly form of the game that threatens to radically alter cricket's traditional moorings to nation. T20 contains in itself the power to render the international game into a historical eccentricity like the Rest day, a practice alive only 12 years ago.

It could do so for a pitifully simple reason: Twenty20 is cricket at its most

sellable, most lucrative. Launched in 2003 to draw crowds to English county grounds, Twenty20's second wave began in 2008, as it married into the world's biggest cricket economy. The private, franchise-driven Indian Premier League (IPL) has turned T20 from a success into a financial windfall for sponsor, broadcaster and player. Bet big on T20—nobody loses.

"I think the 50-over game is in big trouble," says Dave Gilbert, former Australia fast bowler and chief executive Cricket New South Wales. "We should look at it as part of the game's evolution. We are in the entertainment business and people vote with their feet," says Gilbert. Everywhere, people

have voted unequivocally for T20. Audiences of 1,000 for domestic games in Australia, have turned into as many as 25,000 for domestic T20 games. In England, crowd figures for T20 games are six times those of other fixtures.

In this happy, satisfied scenario, the IPL has been a game-changer, a game-breaker. Gilbert says its success left cricket people "mesmerised" — and moving quickly into the market.

Now, there are two seasons of the IPL being planned, one in India and the other a shorter version overseas. This October, its love child, the inaugural Twenty20 Champions League will become the richest club level competition in the history of cricket. Twelve teams,

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UPCOMING SERIES >>

October 2009
T20 CHAMPIONS LEAGUE, INDIA

July, 2010
P20, ENGLAND

2011-2012
SOUTHERN PREMIER LEAGUE

AFRIDI AT THE WORLD T20 FINAL; SYMONDS MAY BE THE FIRST FREELANCE T20 SPECIALIST

Photographs by AP

the top T20 squads from India, South Africa, England, Australia, West Indies, Sri Lanka and New Zealand will compete for \$6 million prize money.

Next year, England will launch its second domestic T20 event, tentatively called the P20, which will feature two divisions of nine teams each, with splashy branding and a distinct identity from the Twenty20 Cup played between 18 counties.

Cricket Australia (CA) are in talks with Cricket South Africa (CSA) to launch the Southern Premier League (SPL) in 2011-2012.

Modelled on the rugby Super 14s, the SPL will feature four teams each from South Africa and Australia-New Zealand.

The quantum of 'domestic' T20 cricket will double in the next two years and everywhere, the IPL formula of inviting big name overseas players has taken hold. CA decided to make available a special grant of A\$50,000 each to buy overseas players for their

